

3 Column Layouts with CSS

Add a sidebar or blog roll.



Template for 3-Column CSS Layout

- Menu Link One
- Menu Link Two
- Menu Link Three

This is a paragraph lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Sed vulputate justo sit amet arcu volutpat sed laoreet nulla luctus. Sed viverra diam vitae quam sollicitudin rhoncus vitae at eros. Donec gravida quam sem. Maecenas id magna nec libero faucibus consectetur.

Phasellus consequat faucibus ornare. Integer arcu mi, scelerisque sit amet dignissim non, luctus posuere magna. Nulla odio est, pretium eget sollicitudin in, dictum nec velit. Curabitur dapibus ullamcorper nisl, in aliquam nibh rhoncus quis.

Phasellus consequat faucibus ornare. Integer arcu mi, scelerisque sit amet dignissim non, luctus posuere magna. Nulla odio est, pretium eget sollicitudin in, dictum nec velit.

This is the footer information.

Start with a 2-Column Template

A fluid three-column layout is built on the standard 2-column layout.

If you already have a 2-col template use that.

Otherwise, start with this HTML code:

```

59 <body>
60 <header>
61 <h1>Template for 3-Column CSS Layout</h1>
62 </header>
63
64 <nav>
65 <ul>
66 <li>Menu Link One</li>
67 <li>Menu Link Two</li>
68 <li>Menu Link Three</li>
69 </ul>
70 </nav>
71
72 <div id="content">
73 <p>
74 This is a paragraph lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit.
    Sed vulputate justo sit amet arcu volutpat sed laoreet nulla luctus. Sed
    viverra diam vitae quam sollicitudin rhoncus vitae at eros. Donec gravida
    quam sem. Maecenas id magna nec libero faucibus consectetur.
75 </p>
76 <p>
77 Phasellus consequat faucibus ornare. Integer arcu mi, scelerisque sit amet
    dignissim non, luctus posuere magna. Nulla odio est, pretium eget
    sollicitudin in, dictum nec velit. Curabitur dapibus ullamcorper nisl, in
    aliquam nibh rhoncus quis. </p>
78 </p>
79 <!-- end of #content -->
80 </div>
81
82 <footer>
83 This is the footer information.
84 </footer>
85 </body>
86 </html>
87

```

Navigation Column

Content Column

And style it using this CSS:

```

12 <style type="text/css">
13 body {
14 background: #F4F4F4;
15 font-family: optima, arial, helvetica, san-serif;
16 font-size: 18px;
17 }
18
19 footer {
20 border: 1px solid blue;
21 clear: both;
22 margin: 0px 10px 10px 0px;
23 padding: 10px;
24 }
25
26 header {
27 background: #1A5B8A; /* dark blue */
28 border: 1px solid purple;
29 color: white;
30 margin: 10px 10px 10px 0px;
31 padding: 0px 10px;
32 }
33
34 nav {
35 background: #ECE6CD; /* cream */
36 border: 1px solid green;
37 float: left;
38 margin: 0px 0px 10px 0px;
39 padding: 0px 10px;
40 width: 20%;
41 }
42
43 p {
44 margin: 1em 0px 1em 0px;
45 padding: 0px 10px;
46 }
47
48 #content {
49 border: 1px solid black;
50 margin: 0px 10px 10px 22%; /* make room for nav on left side */
51 padding: 0px 10px;
52 width: 75%;
53 }
54 </style>

```

Here is the code:

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
```

```
<html>
```

```
<!-- 3colLayoutDemo.html - template for pages with 3-column
layout
```

```
    This is based on the 2colLayoutTemplate.html
```

Author:

Written:

Revised:

-->

<head>

<meta charset="utf-8" />

<title>3col Layout Page</title>

<style type="text/css">

body {

background: #F4F4F4;

font-family: optima, arial, helvetica, san-serif;

font-size: 18px;

}

footer {

border: 1px solid blue;

clear: both;

margin: 0px 10px 10px 0px;

padding: 10px;

}

header {

background: #1A5B8A; /* dark blue */

border: 1px solid purple;

color: white;

margin: 10px 10px 10px 0px;

padding: 0px 10px;

}

nav {

background: #ECE6CD; /* cream */

border: 1px solid green;

float: left;

margin: 0px 0px 10px 0px;

padding: 0px 10px;

width: 20%;

}

```

p {
margin:      1em 0px 1em 0px;
padding:     0px 10px;
}

#content {
border:      1px solid black;
margin:      0px 10px 10px 22%; /* make room for nav on left
side */
padding:     0px 10px;
width:       75%;
}
</style>

</head>

<body>
  <header>
    <h1>Template for 3-Column CSS Layout</h1>
  </header>

  <nav>
    <ul>
      <li>Menu Link One</li>
      <li>Menu Link Two</li>
      <li>Menu Link Three</li>
    </ul>
  </nav>

  <div id="content">
    <p>
      This is a paragraph lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur
      adipiscing elit. Sed vulputate justo sit amet arcu volutpat sed
      laoreet nulla luctus. Sed viverra diam vitae quam sollicitudin
      rhoncus vitae at eros. Donec gravida quam sem. Maecenas id magna
      nec libero faucibus consectetur.
    </p>
    <p>

```

```

Phasellus consequat faucibus ornare. Integer arcu mi,
scelerisque sit amet dignissim non, luctus posuere magna. Nulla
odio est, pretium eget sollicitudin in, dictum nec velit.
Curabitur dapibus ullamcorper nisl, in aliquam nibh rhoncus
quis.  </p>

```

```

</p>

```

```

<!-- end of #content -->

```

```

</div>

```

```

<footer>

```

```

This is the footer information.

```

```

</footer>

```

```

</body>

```

```

</html>

```

And here is what the 2-col page should look like. The two columns overlap because the page is narrowed for the screen shot. The final page will have the borders turned off so this detail won't be important.

<header>

Template for 3-Column CSS Layout

<nav>

- Menu Link One
- Menu Link Two
- Menu Link Three

<div id="content">

This is a paragraph lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Sed vulputate justo sit amet arcu volutpat sed laoreet nulla luctus. Sed viverra diam vitae quam sollicitudin rhoncus vitae at eros. Donec gravida quam sem. Maecenas id magna nec libero faucibus consectetur.

Phasellus consequat faucibus ornare. Integer arcu mi, scelerisque sit amet dignissim non, luctus posuere magna. Nulla odio est, pretium eget sollicitudin in, dictum nec velit. Curabitur dapibus ullamcorper nisl, in aliquam nibh rhoncus quis.

<footer>

This is the footer information.

Add another block to HTML

The trick to adding a third column is to have the HTML set up so the blocks are in the correct order.

1. The column on the left should come first in the HTML code.
2. The column on the far right should come next.
3. And finally, the content will be put third.

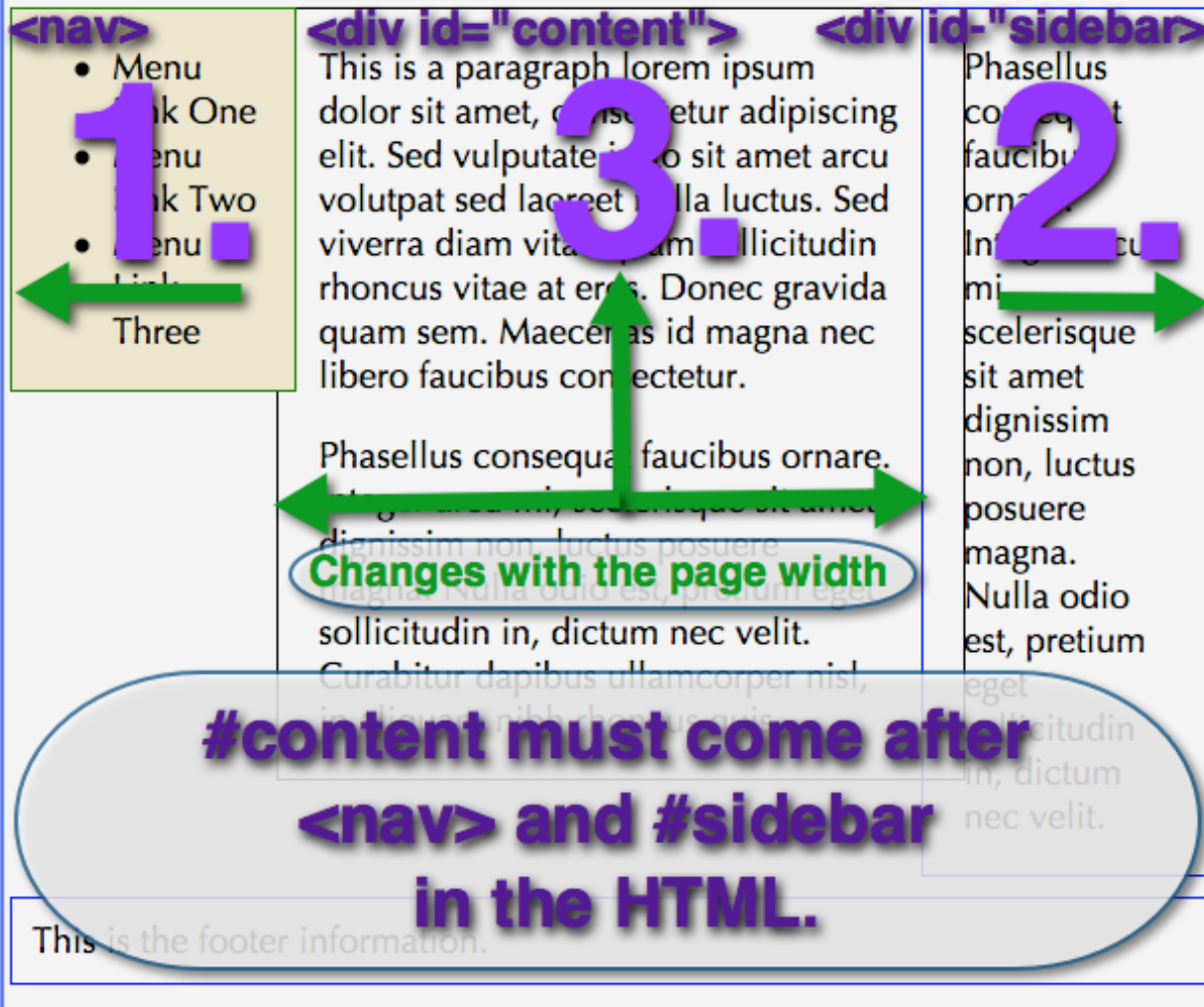
The left-most column will have a float: left and have a narrow width.

The right-most column will have a float: right and have a narrow width.

The content block will then automatically fill in the space between the two columns.

As the page width changes the center column will automatically expand or contract making the layout very fluid.

Template for 3-Column CSS Layout



Here is the HTML code with the new block named "sidebar" added:

```

66 <body>
67   <header>
68     <h1>Template for 3-Column CSS Layout</h1>
69   </header>
70
71   <nav>
72     <ul>
73       <li>Menu Link One</li>
74       <li>Menu Link Two</li>
75       <li>Menu Link Three</li>
76     </ul>
77   </nav>
78
79   <div id="sidebar">
80     <p>
81       Phasellus consequat. Duis ornare. Integer arcu mi, scelerisque sit amet
82       dignissim non, luctus posuere magna. Nulla odio est, pretium eget
83       sollicitudin in, dictum nec velit.
84     </p>
85   </div>
86
87   <div id="content">
88     <p>
89       This is a paragraph lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit.
90       Sed vulputate justo sit amet arcu volutpat sed laoreet nulla luctus. Sed
91       viverra diam vitae quam sollicitudin rhoncus vitae at eros. Donec gravida
92       quam sem. Maecenas magna nec libero faucibus consectetur.
93     </p>
94     <p>
95       Phasellus consequat. Duis ornare. Integer arcu mi, scelerisque sit amet
96       dignissim non, luctus posuere magna. Nulla odio est, pretium eget
97       sollicitudin in, dictum nec velit. Curabitur dapibus ullamcorper nisl, in
98       aliquam nibh rhoncus quis.
99     </p>
100    <!-- end of #content -->
101  </div>
102
103  <footer>
104    This is the footer information.
105  </footer>
106</body>
107</html>

```

Here is the entire <body> element in code:

```

<body>
  <header>
    <h1>Template for 3-Column CSS Layout</h1>
  </header>

  <nav>
    <ul>
      <li>Menu Link One</li>
      <li>Menu Link Two</li>

```

```

        <li>Menu Link Three</li>
    </ul>
</nav>

<div id="sidebar">
<p>
    Phasellus consequat faucibus ornare. Integer arcu mi,
    scelerisque sit amet dignissim non, luctus posuere magna. Nulla
    odio est, pretium eget sollicitudin in, dictum nec velit.
</p>
</div>

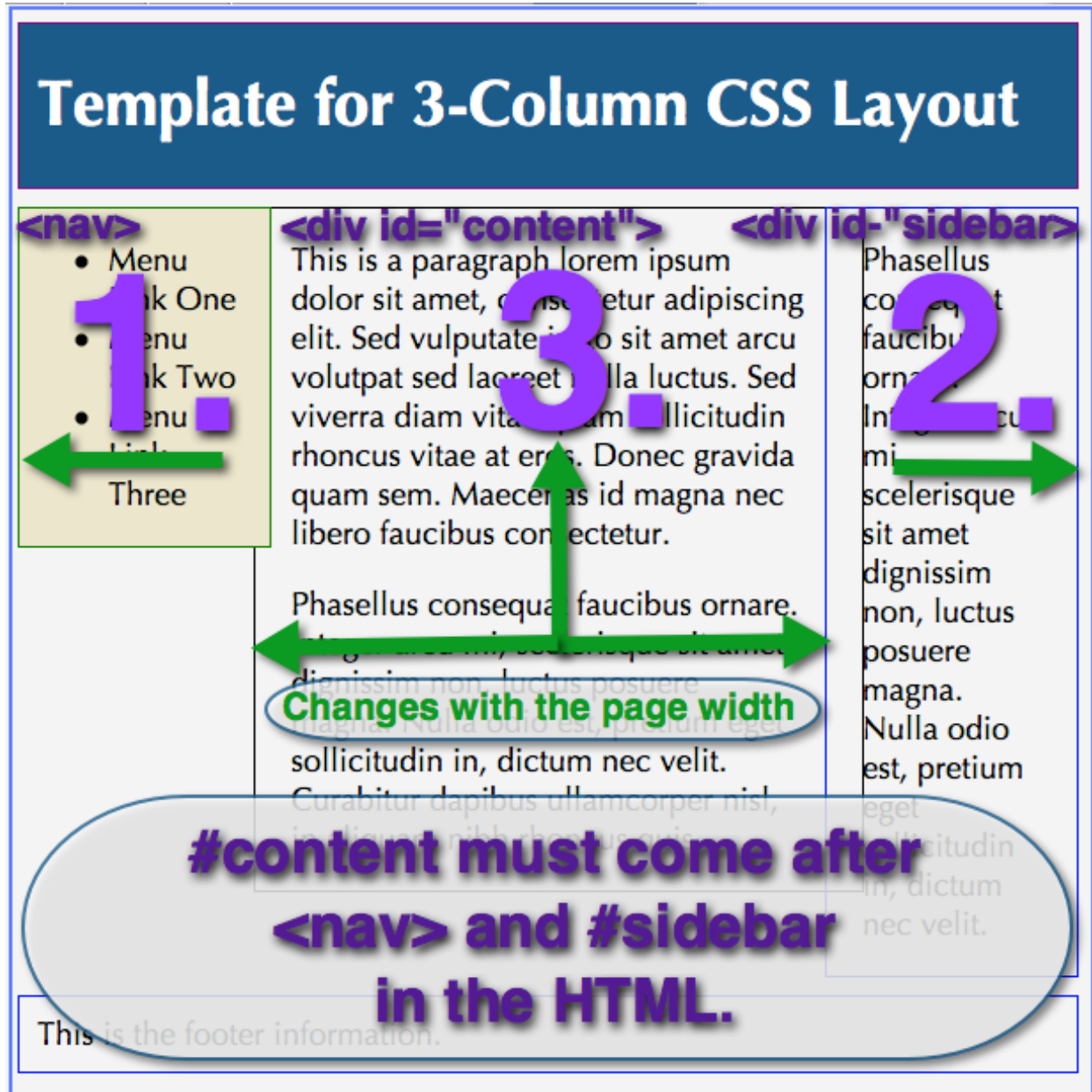
<div id="content">
<p>
    This is a paragraph lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur
    adipiscing elit. Sed vulputate justo sit amet arcu volutpat sed
    laoreet nulla luctus. Sed viverra diam vitae quam sollicitudin
    rhoncus vitae at eros. Donec gravida quam sem. Maecenas id magna
    nec libero faucibus consectetur.
</p>
<p>
    Phasellus consequat faucibus ornare. Integer arcu mi,
    scelerisque sit amet dignissim non, luctus posuere magna. Nulla
    odio est, pretium eget sollicitudin in, dictum nec velit.
    Curabitur dapibus ullamcorper nisl, in aliquam nibh rhoncus
    quis. </p>
</p>
<!-- end of #content -->
</div>

<footer>
    This is the footer information.
</footer>
</body>

```

Style the sidebar block

The columns are positioned by using float left and right for the two outer columns.



Here is the CSS code. Notice that the #content width had to be changed to make room for the third column.

```

33
34 nav {
35   background: #ECE6CD;           /* cream */
36   border:     1px solid green;
37   float:      left;
38   margin:     0px 0px 10px 0px;
39   padding:    0px 10px;
40   width:      20%;
41 }
42
43 p {
44   margin:     1em 0px 1em 0px;
45   padding:    0px 10px;
46 }
47
48 #content {
49   border:     1px solid black;
50   margin:     0px 10px 10px 22%; /* make room for nav on left side */
51   padding:    0px 10px;
52   width:      53%;
53 }
54
55 #sidebar {
56   border:     1px solid blue;
57   float:      right;
58   margin:     0px 10px 10px 10px;
59   padding:    0px 10px;
60   width:      20%;
61 }

```

Here is the entire <style> element with these new changes added:

```

<style type="text/css">
body {
background: #F4F4F4;
font-family: optima, arial, helvetica, san-serif;
font-size: 18px;
}

footer {
border:      1px solid blue;
clear:      both;
margin:     0px 10px 10px 0px;
padding:    10px;
}

header {

```

```

background: #1A5B8A;           /* dark blue */
border:      1px solid purple;
color:       white;
margin:      10px 10px 10px 0px;
padding:     0px 10px;
}

nav {
background: #ECE6CD;           /* cream */
border:      1px solid green;
float:       left;
margin:      0px 0px 10px 0px;
padding:     0px 10px;
width:       20%;
}

p {
margin:      1em 0px 1em 0px;
padding:     0px 10px;
}

#content {
border:      1px solid black;
margin:      0px 10px 10px 22%; /* make room for nav on left
side */
padding:     0px 10px;
width:       53%;
}

#sidebar {
border:      1px solid blue;
float:       right;
margin:      0px 10px 10px 10px;
padding:     0px 10px;
width:       20%;
}
</style>

```

Here is what the page should look like:

| Template for 3-Column CSS Layout | | |
|---|--|--|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none">• Menu Link One• Menu Link Two• Menu Link Three | <p>This is a paragraph lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Sed vulputate justo sit amet arcu volutpat sed laoreet nulla luctus. Sed viverra diam vitae quam sollicitudin rhoncus vitae at eros. Donec gravida quam sem. Maecenas id magna nec libero faucibus consectetur.</p> <p>Phasellus consequat faucibus ornare. Integer arcu mi, scelerisque sit amet dignissim non, luctus posuere magna. Nulla odio est, pretium eget sollicitudin in, dictum nec velit. Curabitur dapibus ullamcorper nisl, in aliquam nibh rhoncus quis.</p> | <p>Phasellus consequat faucibus ornare. Integer arcu mi, scelerisque sit amet dignissim non, luctus posuere magna. Nulla odio est, pretium eget sollicitudin in, dictum nec velit.</p> |
| This is the footer information. | | |

The finished 3-col Template

Finally, remove the borders and add color to the blocks in order to separate them. Notice how the header and footer use the same color scheme giving unity to the page.

While the navigation block and the sidebar are different colors so the user knows (unconsciously) that each column represents different types of information.

```

19 footer {
20   /* border: 1px solid blue; */
21   background: #1A5B8A; /* dark blue */
22   clear: both;
23   color: white;
24   margin: 0px 10px 10px 0px;
25   padding: 10px;
26 }
27
28 header {
29   background: #1A5B8A; /* dark blue */
30   border: 1px solid purple;
31   color: white;
32   margin: 10px 0px 10px 0px;
33   padding: 0px 10px;
34 }
35
36 nav {
37   background: #ECE6CD; /* cream */
38   /* border: 1px solid green; */
39   float: left;
40   margin: 0px 0px 10px 0px;
41   padding: 0px 10px;
42   width: 20%;
43 }
44
45 p {
46   margin: 1em 0px 1em 0px;
47   padding: 0px 10px;
48 }
49
50 #content {
51   /* border: 1px solid black; */
52   margin: 0px 10px 10px 22%; /* make room for nav on left side */
53   padding: 0px 10px;
54   width: 53%;
55 }
56
57 #sidebar {
58   /* border: 1px solid blue; */
59   background: #E3E3E3; /* light gray */
60   float: right;
61   margin: 0px 10px 10px 10px;
62   padding: 0px 10px;
63   width: 20%;
64 }

```

Here is the entire <style> element with all the changes made:

```
<style type="text/css">
```

```
body {
```

```
background: #F4F4F4;
```

```
font-family:optima, arial, helvetica, san-serif;
font-size: 18px;
}
```

```
footer {
/* border:      1px solid blue; */
background: #1A5B8A;          /* dark blue */
clear:      both;
color:      white;
margin:     0px 10px 10px 0px;
padding:    10px;
}
```

```
header {
background: #1A5B8A;          /* dark blue */
border:     1px solid purple;
color:      white;
margin:     10px 0px 10px 0px;
padding:    0px 10px;
}
```

```
nav {
background: #ECE6CD;          /* cream */
/* border:     1px solid green; */
float:      left;
margin:     0px 0px 10px 0px;
padding:    0px 10px;
width:      20%;
}
```

```
p {
margin:     1em 0px 1em 0px;
padding:    0px 10px;
}
```

```
#content {
/* border:     1px solid black; */
margin:       0px 10px 10px 22%; /* make room for nav on left
```

```
side */
padding:    0px 10px;
width:      53%;
}

#sidebar {
/* border:    1px solid blue; */
background:  #E3E3E3;          /* light gray */
float:      right;
margin:     0px 10px 10px 10px;
padding:    0px 10px;
width:      20%;
}
</style>
```

Here is the finished page.

Template for 3-Column CSS Layout

- Menu Link One
- Menu Link Two
- Menu Link Three

This is a paragraph lorem ipsum dolor sit amet, consectetur adipiscing elit. Sed vulputate justo sit amet arcu volutpat sed laoreet nulla luctus. Sed viverra diam vitae quam sollicitudin rhoncus vitae at eros. Donec gravida quam sem. Maecenas id magna nec libero faucibus consectetur.

Phasellus consequat faucibus ornare. Integer arcu mi, scelerisque sit amet dignissim non, luctus posuere magna. Nulla odio est, pretium eget sollicitudin in, dictum nec velit. Curabitur dapibus ullamcorper nisl, in aliquam nibh rhoncus quis.

Phasellus consequat faucibus ornare. Integer arcu mi, scelerisque sit amet dignissim non, luctus posuere magna. Nulla odio est, pretium eget sollicitudin in, dictum nec velit.

This is the footer information.

Summary

Be a smart programmer and save this file in your template folder.

You may want to call it 3colTemplate.html

In the future when you need to build a page with three columns you can open this up and use file/save as, saving it in your current working project folder. This will save you lots of time.

What have you learned?

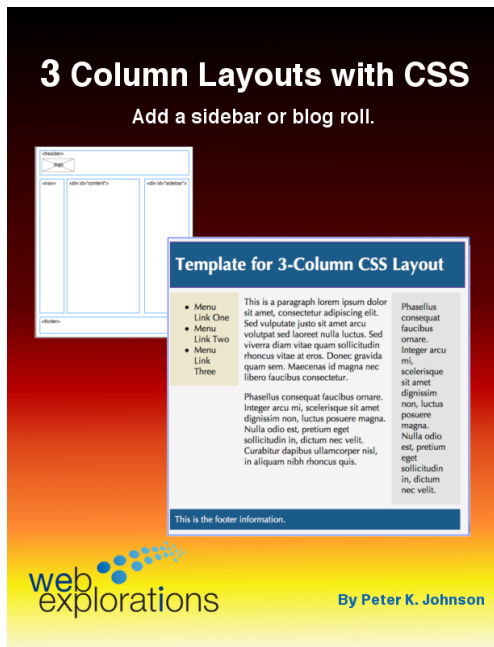
You now know the 3-column layout trick.

1. Set up three blocks in the HTML in the right order: left block, right block, content in the middle.
2. Far left block will have a float: left
3. Far right block will have a float: right
4. The center content block will automatically flow into the space between the two.

Credits

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Peter K. Johnson - <http://WebExplorations.com>
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